



BEFORE

In March 1864, Lincoln put Ulysses S. Grant in charge of all Union armies in the field. Grant's plan called for simultaneous Union advances against Atlanta in the West and against Lee in the East.

LEE VERSUS GRANT

Grant changed the Union objective from the capture of Richmond to the destruction of Lee's Army of Northern Virginia, and established his headquarters with the Army of the Potomac, which, in early 1864, was encamped on the Rapidan River. Grant decided to outflank the Confederate positions across the river by slipping through the Wilderness on the Confederate right, where a year earlier, at the [Battle of Chancellorsville](#), Lee had nearly destroyed the Army of the Potomac.

Before dawn on May 4, 1864, Ulysses S. Grant opened his advance against Robert E. Lee. The first of nearly 120,000 men, 4,300 supply wagons, and 850 ambulances making up the Army of the Potomac crossed the Rapidan River well downstream of Lee's Army of Northern Virginia, nestling behind formidable defenses on the other side.

If Grant could get through the Wilderness, on the Confederate right, before Lee could react, he might lure the Southern general into the open and destroy him. So all day long the blue-clad divisions tramped down the road between walls of somber pines and oak thickets, dense with thorny, foot-entangling vines. It was a "region of gloom and the shadow of death," as one officer put it, and many veterans felt an ominous dread as they went into bivouac that night. Dismayed scouts had reported that Lee, who had been watching the Union army, was on the move, heading swiftly up the Orange Turnpike and Orange Plank Road, parallel tracks that led east into the Wilderness.

The Battle of the Wilderness

Until James Longstreet's First Corps, marching from a different direction, could join him, Lee would be attacking Grant with only one-third of his opponent's strength. Nevertheless, on the morning of May 5 he slammed into a Federal army that was still deploying to meet him. Union troops in Gouverneur Warren's Fifth Corps tried to stem Richard Ewell's Second Corps' onslaught on the Turnpike; 3 miles (4.8km) away, a single Union division held the Brock Road,